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CSE-AIML

Company:Barclays

Job Profile:SDE

Offer Type: Placement Only

CTC:13.5 LPA

Location:Pune

Process Date:OA (26-7-25)

PPT & Interview Rounds (29-7-25)

Placement Process:

The whole recruitment process had three main stages. It started with an OA, which turned out to be the toughest part since it filtered out most of the candidates. Those who cleared the OA were invited for the Pre-Placement Talk (PPT), and then had to go through two rounds of interviews. At the end, there was a fun little prank played on the selected candidates—just to lighten the mood after all the seriousness!. Looking back, clearing the OA was the real challenge. It tested everything like aptitude, computer science fundamentals, and coding skills. So, if you're planning to sit for it, my honest advice would be start preparing early, and make sure you're comfortable with all the core concepts.

1. OA Round [135 candidates appeared, 37 shortlisted]

The Online Assessment (OA) round was conducted in college via the HackerEarth platform. It consisted of three sections:

1. MCQs,
2. A DSA coding question, and
3. An SQL query.

The MCQ section focused mainly on Java fundamentals, especially OOPs concepts. Many questions included code snippets, where we had to guess the output. The questions were quite tricky and concept-based, so a strong grip on the basics really helped.

There was one coding question, which was exactly the same as one asked in a previous Barclays placement drive (here's the [link](#)).

The SQL part was relatively easy—just a basic query where we had to use a WHERE clause along with an AND condition.

#Tip1: Ensure that you are really clear conceptually with OOPs, as different MCQs had differing weightages attached to them. MCQs turned out to be the deciding factor as most students could solve the DSA question and SQL query fully.

#Tip2: Apart from SQL50 on LeetCode, ensure to familiarize yourself with basic String and Date functions and their syntax in SQL.

2. **Tech Round 1** [37 candidates appeared, 19 Shortlisted] (Lasted around 45 Minutes)

The round began with the classic “Introduce Yourself” question. Honestly, this might seem basic, but it’s one of the most important parts. A well-planned intro sets the tone for the rest of the interview and can help steer the conversation toward your strengths and areas you’re comfortable discussing. In my case, I mentioned that I was confident in Java, OOPs, and SQL queries. The interviewer immediately asked me to rate myself in Java out of 10, and from there, he dived straight into OOPs concepts.

OOPs and Java-Focused Questions:

Singleton Class: What it is, when and why to use it.

Inheritance, Abstract Classes, Interfaces: Can an interface extend an abstract class? Can an abstract class implement an interface?

Aggregation , Association: Questions around the class relationships in Java.

Method Overloading vs. Overriding: Why doesn’t compile-time throw an error for method overriding?

Constructor Overloading.

Use of super keyword.

Try-Catch-Finally block: In which cases does the finally block not execute?

He then moved to **Data Structures**. First, he asked me to name the ones I was comfortable with — I mentioned arrays, stacks, linked lists, hashmaps, and heaps.

He gave me 7 numbers and asked me to sort them using each of the data structures I had mentioned. For arrays, stacks, and linked lists, I explained sorting logic for the arrays, stacks, linked list, heaps. In hashmaps, he asked for the use case explanation. I initially used Bubble Sort, but when asked to optimize, I discussed Merge Sort, along with its time complexity.

Then he started **reviewing my resume**. Since React was mentioned, he asked:

About React folder structure.

Specific project-related questions from my resume.

SQL Questions:

First query: Simple one involving LEFT JOIN and WHERE clause.

Follow-up: Slightly extended version with LEFT JOIN, WHERE, and GROUP BY.

Towards the end, he asked if I had any questions. I asked about: "What frameworks like React are used at Barclays, and who exactly uses them in their workflow?"

The interview lasted for about 40 to 45 minutes.

TIPS:

- Master your OOPs concepts — a majority of the questions came from this area.
- If you know the right answer, be confident. Sometimes interviewers may challenge you on purpose just to test your conviction.
- Know your resume inside out. Don't include anything just to fill space — if it's on there, be ready to discuss it.
- For coding problems, always start with the brute force approach. Then discuss how you can optimize it.
- Keep talking through your thoughts during the coding part. Don't go silent. The interaction matters as much as the solution.

3. **Techno-HR round** [19 candidates appeared]

The Techno-HR round began with the usual "Introduce Yourself" question, which helped set a comfortable tone. The interviewer then asked an interesting question: why do you think Java was designed using OOPs? That opened up a deeper conversation about OOP concepts, and he followed up with questions around interfaces, inheritance, and the use of extends and implement keywords.

He then asked me about my internship—what kind of work I did there—and specifically wanted to hear about an incident where I got stuck and how I handled it. It was a good opportunity to share real experience and reflect on problem-solving skills in a work environment. After this, we had a friendly chat about how the software development landscape is evolving. The interviewer casually mentioned how coding nowadays is becoming more about configuring libraries and tools (like in Python) rather than writing every line from scratch. I agreed, and we discussed how that shift is changing the way developers work.

The conversation was very calm and natural. The interviewer was chill and approachable, which made me feel at ease. At one point, he asked me if I preferred being a full-time developer who just codes, or if I'd enjoy a hybrid role like a business analyst—someone who handles tech but also communicates and collaborates with other teams. I appreciated this question because it showed that they were interested in how I see myself professionally, beyond just my tech skills.

After this, he moved to the HR-style situational questions. One of them was quite interesting: he gave me a scenario where I had a deadline the next day, but a teammate was stuck on something. Helping them might mean I'd have to work overnight to finish my own tasks. What would I do? I gave a fairly standard answer—saying that I'd help because it's about the team's success, not just mine. But he challenged me, saying that if I helped, I might lose my own flow and have to restart everything later, which would waste time.

While he was talking, someone served him coffee. He took a sip while reviewing my resume, and I quickly made a connection. I said, “Just like you took a sip of coffee to refresh yourself before continuing, I’d do the same if I were stuck—I’d take a short mental break, help my teammate, and come back even more focused.” That spontaneous answer really clicked with him, and I could see he was impressed.

Then came the question: “Why Barclays?” I had already prepared a response that included their core values—RISES—and wove it into a story that reflected my interest in both tech and impact. He seemed satisfied with the answer.

He also asked me if I preferred working in silence or in a collaborative, discussion-heavy environment. After that, there were a few more classic HR questions—strengths and weaknesses, whether I know anything about finance or investment banking, and if I’d be open to learning a completely new tech stack. He specifically asked if I’d be okay moving away from Java and diving fully into Python or something else if the role required it. I assured him I’m open to learning whatever is needed to grow and contribute effectively.

As the interview was coming to an end, he said he was done and asked if I had any questions for him. I said I wasn’t aware of his position and would love to know more about his role. We ended up having a nice chat about his responsibilities and how teams work at Barclays. It gave me a deeper insight into the company's structure and culture.

The round lasted for around 40 to 45 minutes, and overall, it felt more like a thoughtful conversation than a strict interview.

I’d say it’s really important to be aware of Barclays' RISES values and try to include them naturally in your responses to situation-based questions. Preparing some standard HR questions in advance helps a lot, especially if you can back up your answers with real stories. In my case, I used internship experiences and examples from project collaborations. It's also important to interact with the interviewer—don’t just turn it into a Q&A session. Try to make it a discussion. Stay attentive, because small things happening around you can give you the spark for a clever or memorable answer—but make sure you don’t get distracted. And lastly, whatever your strengths are, try to reflect them—directly or indirectly—throughout the interview. One more thing that really helped me was paying attention during the PPT (Pre-Placement Talk). Some of the things discussed there—especially around the company’s work culture, Barclays’ values, and the tech stack they use—came in handy during the HR and project discussion parts. So I’d strongly suggest taking notes during the PPT, because it can give you useful context and even points to connect during the actual interview.

After a long wait, there was a prank where 16 candidates were called and finally we were told that we have been.

Resources:

Aptitude: [indiabix](#)

DSA striver sheet :[LINK](#) Practice questions repeatedly and get familiar with all the common patterns.

SQL : [SQL 50](#) Practice SQL 50 from LeetCode at least 2–3 times before placements, and make sure to cover questions on date and time functions as well.

JAVA OOPS: can read [GFG](#) along with that [aryan mittle's](#) oops playlist is also good.

All the best for your placement!

Prepare well, trust your luck, and enjoy the journey — it teaches you a lot about handling stress and managing time. Yes, the process can feel hectic, full of stress and overwhelming, but once you're selected, all the effort truly feels worth it.

Feel free to reach out: [LinkedIn](#)